

Piano Lessons for Absolute Beginners

Lesson 3: Finger Numbers & Basic Hand Position

Finger Numbers & Basic Hand Position - Study Notes

Key Concepts

- **Finger Numbering System:** Understanding the universal numbering system for fingers (1-5).
- **Curved Finger Shape:** Maintaining a natural curve in the fingers, like holding a ball.
- **Relaxed Wrists:** Keeping wrists level and relaxed, avoiding bending.
- **C Position:** The starting hand position placing fingers on C, D, E, F, and G.
- **Muscle Memory:** Building familiarity and coordination through repetition.

Summary

This lesson introduces the fundamental building blocks for playing the piano: finger numbering and proper hand position. The finger numbering system (Thumb = 1, Index = 2, etc.) is a universal standard used in all piano music, allowing for clear communication between teachers and students and within sheet music itself. Equally important is establishing a correct hand position. The key is to imagine holding a small ball in each hand – this encourages a natural curve in your fingers and prevents them from being flat or tense.

Maintaining relaxed wrists, level and not bent, is crucial for preventing strain and allowing for fluid movement. We begin practicing this with "C position," where your right-hand fingers are placed on the C, D, E, F, and G keys, corresponding to fingers 1 through 5. Consistent repetition of this exercise, focusing on the curved finger shape and relaxed wrists, will build muscle memory and lay a solid foundation for future piano playing.

Important Points

- **Finger Numbers:**
 - * Thumb = 1
 - * Index Finger = 2
 - * Middle Finger = 3
 - * Ring Finger = 4
 - * Pinky Finger = 5
- **Hand Shape:** Imagine holding a small ball in each hand.
- **Finger Curve:** Fingers should be curved, not flat or stiff.
- **Wrist Position:** Wrists should be relaxed and level – avoid bending them up or down.
- **C Position:** Right hand: 1 (C), 2 (D), 3 (E), 4 (F), 5 (G).
- **Repetition is Key:** Practice C position repeatedly to build muscle memory.
- **Tension Prevention:** Proper hand position helps prevent hand and wrist strain.

Examples

Example 1: Reading a Simple Exercise

Imagine you see the following instruction in a beginner piano book: "Play finger 3 on E." This means you should use your middle finger (finger number 3) to press the E key.

****Example 2: Practicing C Position****

Place your right hand on the keyboard. Finger 1 (thumb) on C, Finger 2 (index) on D, Finger 3 (middle) on E, Finger 4 (ring) on F, and Finger 5 (pinky) on G. Ensure your fingers are curved and your wrists are relaxed. Lift all fingers off the keys, then repeat, focusing on maintaining the correct shape and feeling. Do this 5-10 times.

Quick Review

1. What finger number corresponds to the index finger?
2. Why is it important to imagine holding a ball when forming your hand position?
3. In C position, which finger (number) is placed on the F key?
4. What should you do to prevent tension in your wrists while playing?
5. Why is repetition important when learning hand position?

Further Reading

- ****Scales:**** Learning basic scales (like the C major scale) will reinforce finger numbers and hand position.
- ****Arpeggios:**** Practicing arpeggios helps develop finger dexterity and coordination.
- ****Posture:**** Research proper posture for playing the piano – it's connected to relaxed wrists and efficient playing.
- ****Hand Exercises:**** Explore simple hand stretches and exercises to maintain flexibility and prevent injury.
- ****Different Hand Positions:**** Learn about other common hand positions beyond C position (e.g., G position).

